JUST TRANSITION PLAN

February 2025

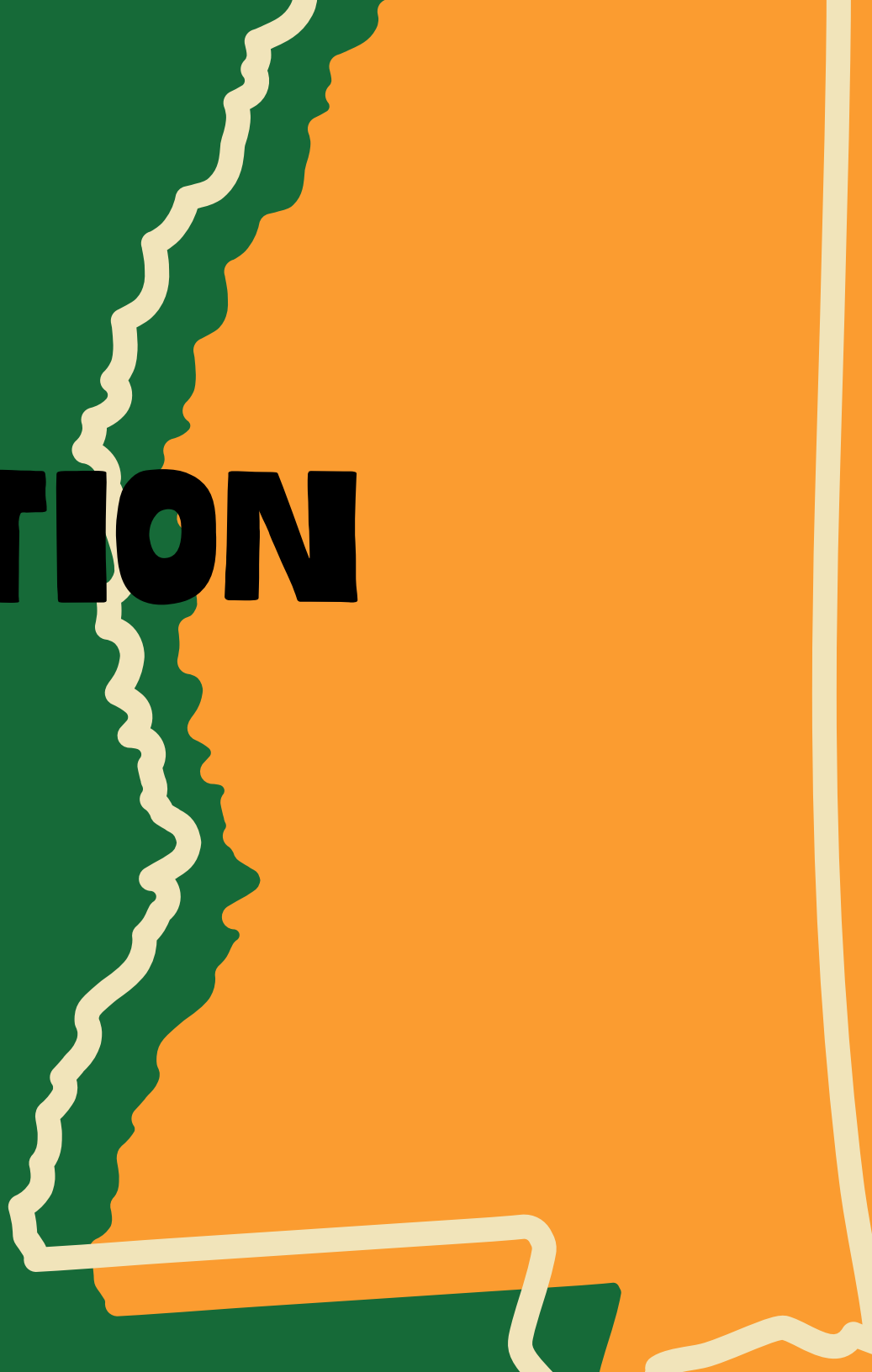


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As the threat of the climate crisis multiplies by the day, the urgency of wide scale social mobilization similarly grows. The question of saving our planet requires complex and multidimensional solutions that draw from the expertise of a diverse set of people. In addition to securing a safe climate future, it's essential a new world on the horizon is one where life is better for billions of people. The purpose of this document, compiled by the Mississippi People's Movement and Great Plains Institute, is to articulate beyond a climate transition, the possibilities for a Just Transition[1] in our state. We ask a central, organizing question: what does it look like to move towards a carbon-free economy while improving the livelihoods of Mississippians?

MPM emerged from Gulf South for a Green New Deal, a collective of organizers from Texas, Louisiana, Mississippi, Alabama, Puerto Rico, and Florida working to imagine and advocate for a just environmental future. Described as a "uniquely Southern vision and approach to global climate crisis," Gulf South for a Green New Deal engaged local, community-based networks to create an economy where people and the planet can thrive. In 2024, Mississippi independently began to build internal capacity and chart out state-specific plans. As stated in the group's mission:

> Mississippi People's Movement (MPM) is a collaborative alliance of more than 20 frontline groups across Mississippi committed to building a more just, equitable, and sustainable Mississippi. Through advocacy, education, and community engagement, we empower marginalized communities, promote climate justice, and advance economic and social equity. By fostering solidarity and grassroots leadership, we strive to create a future where all residents can thrive in a healthy society that values justice, equity, and environmental stewardship.[2]

In the coming years, Mississippi will face increasingly serious harm from a warming planet. Damage from tropical storms will increase, crop yields will suffer, and heat-related illnesses will become more common. The Mississippi coastline is expected to rise between twenty inches to four feet in the next century and flooding will increase. All these factors will overwhelmingly raise costs of energy and insurance as critical infrastructure gets damaged.[3] Without question, action is urgent.

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1 A Just Transition describes a move away from an economy powered by fossil fuels to one that is powered by clean, renewable, and decarbonized energy. Simultaneously, this process emphasizes the need for people's lives to improve because of the transition.

2 https://www.msrising.com/mpm

3 https://19january2017snapshot.epa.gov/sites/production/files/2016-09/documents/climate-change-ms.pdf


EXIT



MISSISSIPPI'S PRIORITY CLIMATE ACTION PLAN

Using a set of tools developed by the EPA, the Mississippi Department of Environmental Quality conducted an assessment of the state's greenhouse gas (GHG) inventory. Notably, the extensive forested parts of the state function as a significant carbon sink, making Mississippi a net-zero or net-negative state in-terms of emissions. Still, there exists a high level of potential for the state to reduce GHGs to improve people's quality of life and reduce harms of climate change. Mississippi has the opportunity to lead by intentionally developing a strategy to significantly cut emissions and deploy clean alternatives to fossil fuel emissions.

The Priority Climate Action Plan (PCAP) looked at emissions across five sectors: electric power generation, transportation, industry, agriculture, buildings, and wastewater. The PCAP outlines fourteen GHG reduction measures that are both quantitative and narrative in order to support state, local, and regional governments and agencies to access funding to enable climate action.

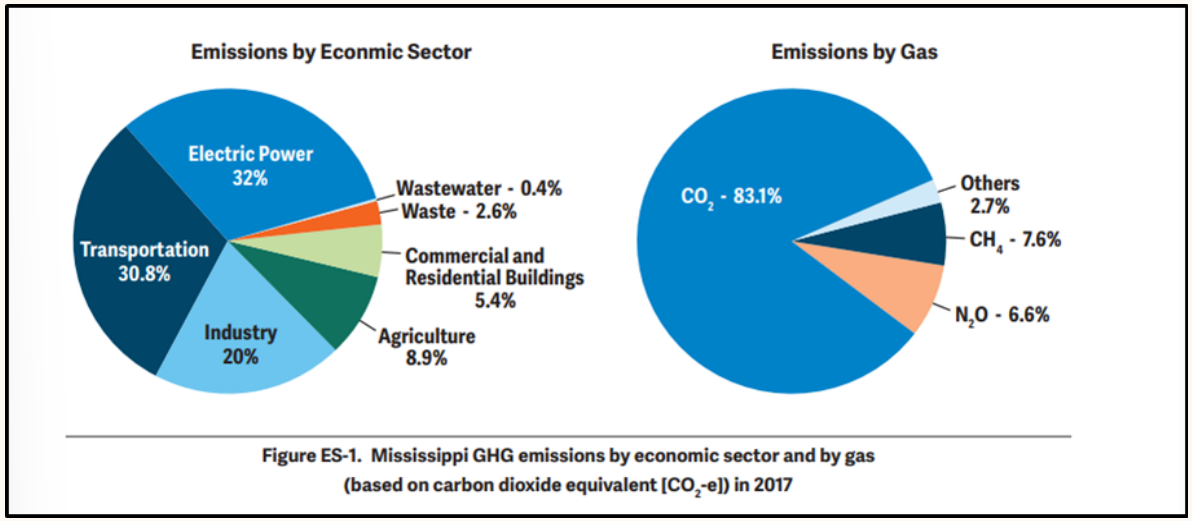


Figure ES-1. Mississippi GHG emissions by economic sector and by gas (based on carbon dioxide equivalent [CO_2-e]) in 2017

Source: https://www.epa.gov/system/files/documents/2024-03/ms-pcap.pdf
Graphics created by Tetra Tech Inc. and property of MDEQ

Within the PCAP is a survey which identifies the top priorities of Mississippi residents when it comes to reducing climate change impacts. Air and water quality top the list followed by more sustainable food systems and a transition to renewable energy. Summaries of interviews with hub members (page 3) – constituent organizations in the Mississippi People's Movement— similarly map onto these survey results.

This document is meant to serve as a guide for future advocacy and organizing around climate.
It is not exhaustive but in line with the expressed values of Mississippi People's Movement hub members.

As MPM hub members deepen their knowledge around climate action, this document will evolve to reflect those values and principles. This document begins with a synthesis of themes communicated by MPM members during one-on-one interviews. Next, it outlines major takeaways from the Climate Learning Convening. It concludes with a set of policy goals with political, economic, and community-based mechanisms to achieve them.

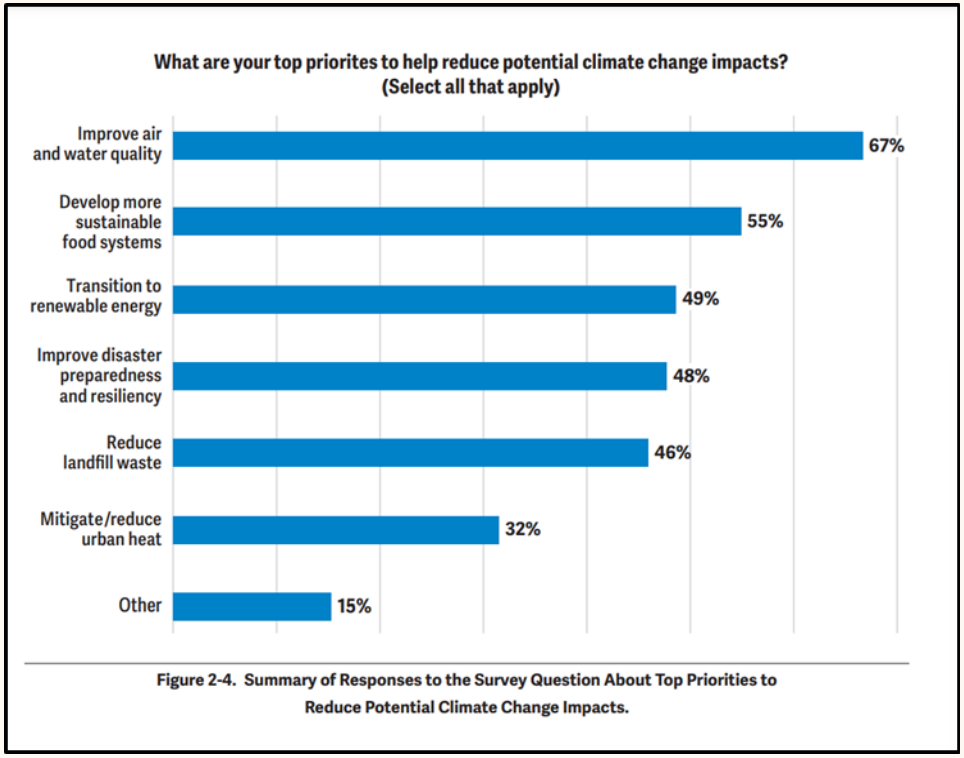


Figure 2-4. Summary of Responses to the Survey Question About Top Priorities to Reduce Potential Climate Change Impacts.

Source: https://www.epa.gov/system/files/documents/2024-03/ms-pcap.pdf
Graphics created by Tetra Tech Inc. and property of MDEQ



MAJOR THEMES FROM MPM HUB MEMBER INTERVIEWS

Over the course of several interviews with hub members, major themes emerged across conversations.

These interviews were conducted between June and August of 2024 to understand the priorities of MPM members and capture their vision for an equitable climate future. The following themes reflect the views of interviewed members, and the highlighted organizations contributed specific insights which informed key features of the Just Transition plan.

1. Environmental Justice and Climate Advocacy

- Mississippi has a long history of prioritizing economic development over the well-being of people. Although economic security is an important value, the state does not do enough to address environmental racism and systemic inequities in the way it addresses key issues like zoning, pollution, and resource distribution.
- Community-led decision-making and self-determination are noticeably absent from government processes like permitting. Despite community members' lack of buy-in for a project, the projects go through anyway.
- There is skepticism that large companies use greenwashing tactics to stay in business rather than substantively moving away from a fossil fuel economy.
- Climate resilience for marginalized communities needs to be a focus. People need to be knowledgeable and prepared when dealing with crisis.

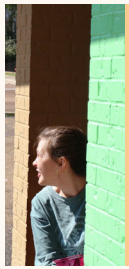


Organizations:

- EEECHO
- People's Advocacy Institute (PAI)
- Jesus People Against Pollution (JPAP)

2. Just Transition

- There needs to be a transition from harmful and polluting industries to ones that are locally-based and sustainable.
- In the process of transitioning to more sustainable forms of energy, equity needs to be a central principle. Low-income and communities of color should not bear the brunt of an energy transition but instead be better off as a result.
- As the transition to a green economy occurs, workers should have clear pathways to access high quality, well-paying jobs. Supporting workers and communities impacted by climate policies needs to happen alongside progressive climate policy.
- Communities have the answers and need to be primary decision-makers in the transition to a green economy.



Organizations:

- Jobs to Move America (JMA)
- Mississippi Farm to School Network
- Choctaw Fresh Produce

3. Community Control and Mobilization

- Communities need to lead environmental, social, and economic initiatives and have the resources to do so effectively.
- It is hard work to develop community buy-in and build capacity. The economic and social obligations—and often, burdens—people already experience make it difficult to mobilize communities towards long-term climate action.
- When community-led work occurs, it's important to communicate with stakeholders in an inclusive way and ensure collective decision making is happening. Participatory budgeting is one such process to accomplish this model of work.
- Communities are vast and multifaceted. There is no "one view." Community leaders need to be advocates and uplift a multiplicity of viewpoints.



Organizations:

- Hijra House
- East Biloxi Food Market
- Tupelo Mutual Aid

4. Challenges from Polluting Industries

- In Mississippi, there is no shortage of industries that perpetuate harms in local communities. Industrial projects like petrochemicals, poultry plants, and waste dumping cause health harms that disproportionately impact the most disadvantaged people.
- Health impacts range from asthma, cancer, chemical explosions, and illnesses from water contamination are common.
- Inequitable permitting processes favor large corporations because of promises of economic opportunity. The promised economic benefits rarely help people already in the community.
- Utility companies like Entergy and Southern Company do not have any plans in place to transition away from fossil fuels to renewables.



Organizations:

- Healthy Gulf
- MEOA Consulting
- CODAGIS Consulting

5. Energy Transition

- There is enthusiasm around solar, wind, and other renewables over fossil fuels. Similarly, there is a strong desire to learn more about these forms of energy and what impact they might have on communities.
- Uncertainty around how climate technologies work increases people's hesitancy around adoption, especially in their communities.
- That said, potential cost increases because of an energy transition, especially for vulnerable communities, is a major concern.



Organizations:

- Program Believe
- New Bethel CDC
- Healthy Gulf

6. Food Access and Sustainable Agriculture

- It is a priority for hub members to support local farmers and develop a more robust network of sustainable food systems.
- Food deserts need to be eliminated and community involvement in agricultural practices should be ensured.
- As the climate continues to change, food producers need access to greater education about climate resilience.

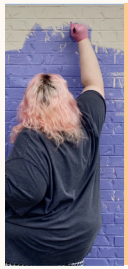


Organizations:

- Mississippi Farm to School Network
- Choctaw Fresh Produce
- Mississippi Center for Cultural Production

7. Education and Capacity-Building

- Community members need to be informed about environmental threats, solutions, and the rights they possess to advocate for a more equitable future.
- Environmental justice should be incorporated into youth and adult education.
- Training for workforce development in green industries needs to happen as a part of the economy's transition.



Organizations:

- Program Believe
- Mississippi Educators Organizers Alliance (MEOA)

BUILDING TRUST AND CAPACITY FOR COMMUNITIES IN MISSISSIPPI

This section synthesizes experiences of MPM members when working with external partners and pathways for moving forward to achieve a clean energy economy.

Trauma from External Partnerships

- Communities in Mississippi often distrust outside groups due to past unkept promises and harmful experiences.
- Communities have faced lies, unreliable actors, and interpersonal harm from prior partnerships.
- Despite past trauma, communities are open to collaboration if external partners articulate clear goals, engage responsibly, and establish accountability.
- Plans can change, but communities should always be informed and involved in changes to maintain trust.

Building Community Capacity for Input and Engagement

- Developers and governments increasingly prioritize input, but a long-term strategy to build capacity is essential.
- Three Pillars of Capacity Building:
  - Funding: Federal grants exist but are complex to apply for and manage, putting strain on community organizations.
  - Expertise: Partnerships with trusted experts and institutions help organizations navigate dense or technical issues like industrial decarbonization and carbon management.
  - Organizing: Building strong networks requires dedicated time, people-power, and sustained resources.
- Capacity building enables organizations to address immediate needs while planning for the long term.

Building Trust with Communities

- Building trust requires a history of keeping promises and ongoing demonstrations of commitment.



- Key Questions for Partners:
  - Can you prove reliability through past actions?
  - Are you accessible and supportive of community needs?
  - Even with best efforts, trust may not be immediate. Sometimes, it's better to pause a project and rebuild trust over time.

Climate Education and Understanding the Big Picture

- Community members want to understand details about climate drivers, solutions, and their impacts.
- People need to understand the "why" behind climate technologies like renewables, carbon capture, and hydrogen.
- Linking climate education to broader economic and industrial transitions helps communities grasp necessary steps.

Long-Term Visioning for Short-Term Policy Goals

- Community members affirmed the need for energy-intensive industries like aviation, steel, AI, and cars in Mississippi's future.
- Aligning the long-term vision with short-term policy measures ensures practical steps toward a just transition.
- Visioning exercises help outline clear goals for Mississippi's future economy and energy systems.



CHARTING A PATH FORWARD TO ADVANCE A JUST TRANSITION

There is no shortage of promising climate solutions. The plummeting cost of solar and wind energy, for example, offer an economically viable alternative to an entrenched dependency on a fossil fuel economy. Practices around degrowth—aligning consumption as not to overextend planetary limits—are immediately available. Emerging industries like solar radiation management (SRM) promise tools to decrease rising temperatures through practices like cloud brightening where sunlight is reflected into space. With these solutions also come costs. In the case of solar and wind, power generation is not possible 24 hours, 7 days a week. Asking people to consume less or work less in a shift towards degrowth goes against the intensely capitalist principles that undergird the economy. SRM and other geoengineering processes are so new and untested, any benefits they do deliver might come with disastrous consequences ranging from flood to famine.

The work of climate action is largely identifying which costs we are willing to accept.

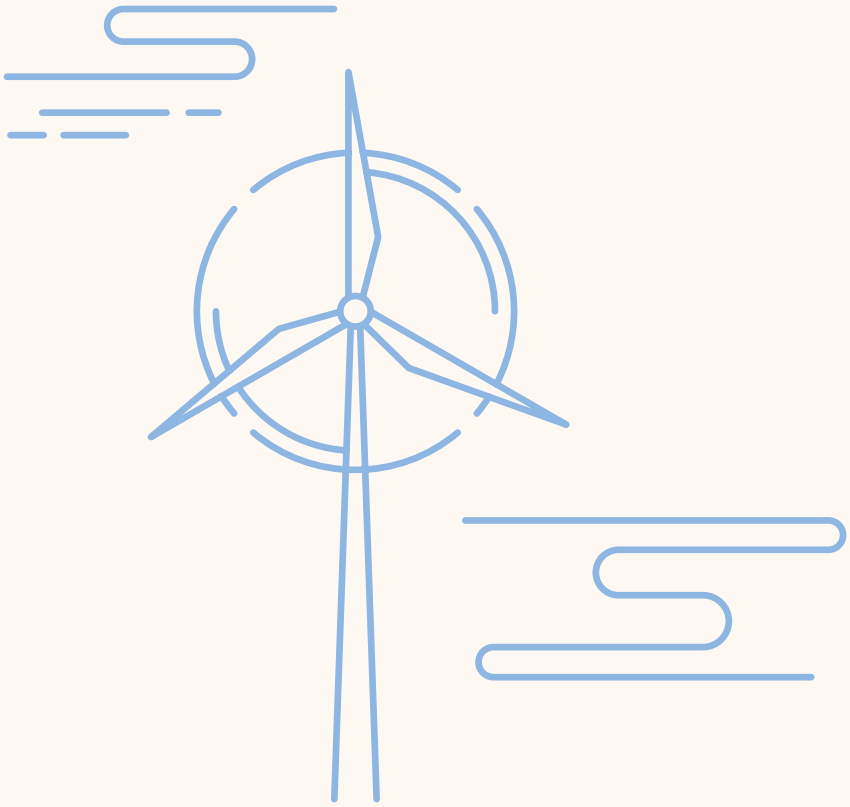
In charting a path forward to advance a Just Transition for Mississippi, this section focuses less on the nuances of each possible solution, but on the broader strategies necessary for the transition to be possible. Further, it identifies specific actors interested in doing climate work in Mississippi—from state and federal agencies to private developers—to successfully execute projects and secure community support. Finally, it maps areas of opportunity. These are pathways communities should orient their efforts towards in order to consistently win on climate.

These recommendations outline a broad set of policy options. The diversity of Mississippi's communities requires a similar breadth of pathways to decarbonization. In addition to the rapid reduction of greenhouse gasses, people's improved livelihoods is a necessary outcome of this work. As people decide which set of solutions work best for them, these recommendations offer a guide.



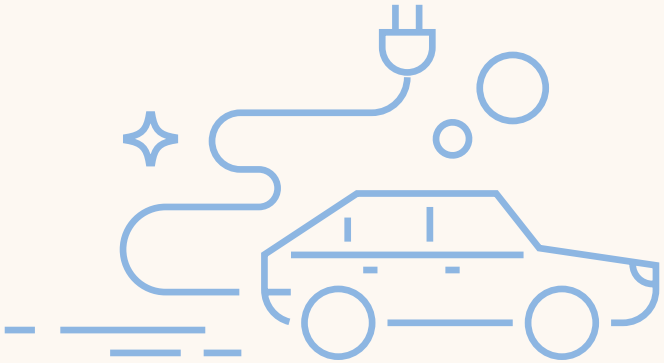
Decarbonizing the Power Sector (adopted from Stanford Energy)

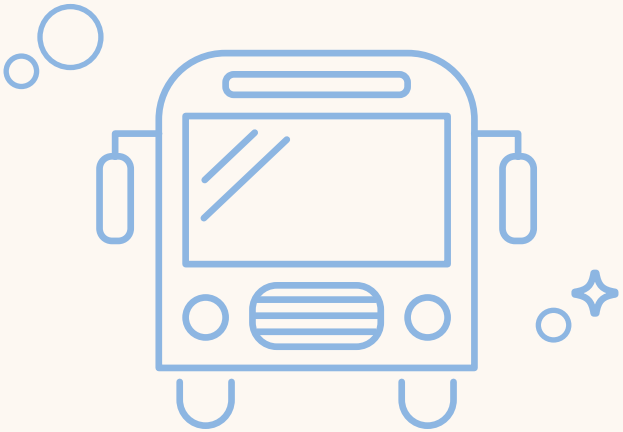
- Transition the power sector away from coal and natural gas toward renewable energy sources such as solar, wind, and geothermal energy.
- Building energy storage: Invest in short and long-term battery storage capacity to be charged when renewable generation exceeds load and deployed when load exceeds renewable generation capacity.
- Flexible load systems: Create systems where periods of high renewable generation match high load demand to decrease reliance on fossil fuels and storage.
- Overbuild: Create more renewable generation than needed and work with communities to account for land needs.
- Grid integration: Expand Mississippi's grid connections to other regions in the United States to reduce renewable variability.
- Expanding the use of nuclear energy as a clean energy source.



Decarbonizing Transportation

- Vehicle electrification: Transitioning from internal combustion engine vehicles to electric vehicles (EVs) powered by clean electricity. This includes passenger cars, buses, trucks, and other modes of transportation, helping to reduce greenhouse gas emissions and air pollution.
- Net-zero and low-carbon fuels: Developing and deploying fuels that have minimal lifecycle greenhouse gas emissions. Examples include biofuels, synthetic fuels, and hydrogen produced using renewable energy.
- Energy system integration: Coordinating energy generation, storage, and consumption systems to maximize efficiency and reliability. This approach connects renewable energy sources with EVs, charging infrastructure, and other energy-dependent systems to create a flexible, low-carbon energy network.
- State-wide network of charging stations: Building an extensive, accessible network of EV charging stations across the state to support the widespread adoption of electric vehicles. This includes fast chargers on highways, workplace chargers, and residential charging solutions.
- Developing and scaling sustainable aviation fuel: Advancing the production and use of SAF, which is derived from renewable resources like waste oils, plant materials, or captured carbon. SAF can significantly reduce the carbon footprint of air travel while utilizing existing aviation infrastructure.
- Promoting urban density, walkability, and bikeability to reduce reliance on fossil fuel-powered transportation and create healthier, more sustainable communities.





Decarbonizing Buildings (adopted from Center for Climate and Energy Solutions)

- Transition to energy-efficient building practices, electrification wherever possible, and renewable power sources.
- Incentivize landlords to install rooftop solar to ensure access for renters and non-homeowners.
- Promote dense housing and commercial development to maximize energy efficiency.
- Require the adoption of the latest energy codes to ensure new and renovated buildings meet high efficiency standards.
- Implement performance-based policies to drive energy efficiency improvements in existing buildings over time.
- Promote the use of energy-efficient heat pumps for heating and cooling to lower emissions and reduce energy consumption.
- Encourage the adoption of electric induction stoves, which improve indoor air quality and help reduce asthma rates, while decreasing reliance on fossil fuels.

Decarbonizing Industry (adopted from Department of Energy)[4]

- Manage industrial systems to maximize energy efficiency through optimization of thermal heat and data analytics to increase energy productivity.
- Electrify as many industrial processes as possible with heat pumps and electrochemical approaches.
- Use low-carbon fuels like biofuels and hydrogen to minimize CO_2 emissions.
- For industries that require high heat and heavy-duty processes (ex. cement, steel), implementing carbon capture technologies and using hydrogen as a fuel source where renewables are insufficient.



4 The industrial sector is vast and complex. Like all sectors of the economy, it requires solutions that work for manufacturers and community members. MPM emphasizes the importance of electrification pathways that utilize renewable energy as the primary pathway to achieving decarbonization. Carbon management technologies should be deployed when a renewable solution is not possible. Further, any captured carbon dioxide should not be used for enhanced oil recovery.

Decarbonizing Agriculture (adopted from National Renewable Energy Laboratory)

Pre-Production Policies

- Reduced energy and greenhouse gas intensity of ammonia production: Implementing energy-efficient technologies and cleaner energy sources in the production of ammonia, a key ingredient in fertilizer and other chemicals, to lower emissions.
- Solar and wind water desalination: Using renewable energy sources like solar and wind to power the desalination of water for agricultural use, reducing reliance on fossil fuels.
- On-site renewable energy production: Installing solar panels, wind turbines, or other renewable energy systems on farms to meet energy needs locally.

Production Policies

- Combine solar energy production with agricultural activities on the same land, optimizing land use for both food and clean energy.
- Produce ammonia using renewable energy or carbon capture to power the minimize greenhouse gas use.
- Solar and wind-powered pumping and irrigation: Replacing fossil fuel-powered systems with renewable energy-powered systems for water pumping and irrigation in farming operations.
- Electrification of equipment and on-farm activities: Transitioning farm equipment and processes to electric alternatives, reducing reliance on diesel and gasoline.
- Anaerobic digestion: Utilizing organic waste to produce biogas through anaerobic digestion, reducing methane emissions and providing a renewable energy source.
- Precision agriculture: Leveraging data and technology to optimize resource use, improve efficiency, and reduce environmental impacts.
- Agroforestry: Integrating trees and shrubs into agricultural landscapes to enhance biodiversity, sequester carbon, and provide additional ecosystem benefits.
- Biochar application: Applying biochar, a form of charcoal, to soils to improve fertility, sequester carbon, and reduce greenhouse gas emissions.

Enhanced Agricultural Practices

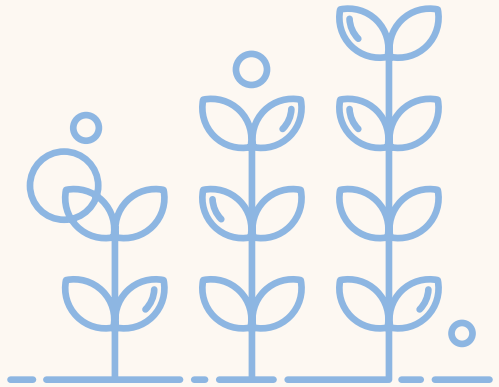
- Enhanced efficiency fertilizers: Using advanced fertilizers that release nutrients more effectively, reducing waste and environmental impacts.
- Irrigation strategies: Implementing efficient irrigation techniques, such as drip irrigation, to conserve water and reduce energy consumption.
- Cover crops: Planting crops that cover the soil during off-seasons to improve soil health, prevent erosion, and sequester carbon.
- No-till systems: Avoiding plowing to reduce soil disturbance, improve soil structure, and lower emissions from farming equipment.



- Diversified crop rotation: Alternating crops in a sequence to improve soil health, reduce pest pressure, and increase resilience to climate change.
- Intercropping: Growing multiple crops together to maximize land use efficiency, improve soil health, and enhance biodiversity.
- Feed additives for livestock: Incorporating specific additives in animal feed to reduce methane emissions from digestion.

Postproduction Policies

- Streamlined distribution chains: Optimizing supply chains to reduce the time and energy required to transport agricultural products.
- Use of fuel-efficient transportation: Adopting more fuel-efficient vehicles or alternative energy sources for transporting goods.
- Reductions in energy demand for freight travel: Implementing strategies to minimize energy consumption in logistics, such as better route planning and energy-efficient vehicles.
- Solar fruit drying and food production: Using solar energy to dry fruits and produce food items, reducing energy use and emissions.
- Biomass-powered milling, pressing, and grinding: Utilizing agricultural waste as biomass fuel for processing tasks, creating a renewable energy loop.
- Cogeneration of heat and power in processing: Generating electricity and usable heat simultaneously during processing to maximize energy efficiency and reduce emissions.



Carbon Dioxide Removal Strategies (adopted from Carbon 180)

- A combination of natural and engineered solutions can effectively remove carbon dioxide (CO_2) from the atmosphere. These strategies are vital because the current levels of atmospheric CO_2 are dangerously high, contributing to severe global warming effects.
- Biomass Carbon Removal and Storage: Harvested plants can be buried and stored underground to prevent carbon emissions. Biomass can also be transformed into valuable products, including:
  - Biochar, a solid that improves agricultural yields.
  - Bio-oil, a liquid that serves as an energy resource.
- Carbon dioxide, which can be captured and stored underground to prevent its release into the atmosphere.
- Direct Air Capture (DAC): DAC technologies use chemical solvents to extract CO_2 directly from the air. The captured CO_2 can then be safely stored deep underground or converted for beneficial use in products, helping to reduce atmospheric greenhouse gases.
- Enhanced Rock Weathering: Crushed basalt rocks, when spread across agricultural fields, react with CO_2 in the air to form bicarbonates. This process not only sequesters carbon but also enriches the soil with essential nutrients, boosting agricultural productivity.
- Forest Carbon Removal: Implementing effective forest management practices, such as minimizing fire risks, enhances the capacity of forests to sequester large amounts of carbon while preserving biodiversity.
- Soil Carbon Removal: Improved land management techniques, including planting cover crops and practicing managed grazing, can significantly increase the amount of carbon stored in soils, enhancing soil health and resilience.
- Storage and Utilization: Once removed, CO_2 can be:
  - Stored safely in geological formations thousands of feet underground.
  - Utilized to produce a range of sustainable products, such as aviation fuels, construction materials, and even beer, turning carbon waste into valuable resources.

COMMUNITY PROTECTIONS

Free Prior and Informed Consent Standard

The deployment of many climate technologies still comes with risk and potential harm. It is important to recognize the costs of inaction will be disastrous and good policy implementation will enable a rapid energy transition while minimizing any harm. The Indigenous Peoples' principle of the Free, Prior, and Informed Consent (FPIC) standard is a framework to ensure community voice in the development of projects. All communities must be thoroughly informed about any development which impacts land, water, and mineral resources. Similarly, any legislative or administrative actions that impact communities must be clearly and transparently communicated. Communities should have the opportunity to participate as essential stakeholders when a new project is proposed to ensure the protection of economic, social, cultural, spiritual, and environmental priorities.

Finally, the state and private actors must accept a "no" when communities veto project development.[5]

Cumulative impact assessments and community benefit plans and agreements are tools to identify what implications a project will have for communities and the environment. They also offer pathways to enshrine the decision-making authority of communities.

Cumulative Impact Assessments[6]

- As defined by an Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) report, cumulative impacts are " the totality of exposures to combinations of chemical and non-chemical stressors and their effects on

5 https://www.ienearth.org/fpic/

6 Forest carbon removal is a useful case in highlighting the value of cumulative impact assessments. Planting trees and avoiding forest fires through effective management practices avoids increased carbon dioxide emissions. However, felled trees result in the growth of a wood pellet industry that increases air pollution, that increases harm. Similarly, if wood pellets are shipped overseas, transportation emissions can outweigh any carbon removal benefits. This form of analysis is relevant for all listed technologies. Solar panels require large quantities of land, carbon capture technologies are expensive to deploy, and electric cars prevent dense urban planning. Communities, policymakers, and developers need to be attentive to the overall impact of any clean energy project to ensure that people and the environment benefit.



health, well-being, and quality of life outcomes."[7] When new developments are proposed in an area, it's important that communities have a clear understanding of the benefits and harms a project might bring.

- Cumulative Impact Assessments are tools to evaluate the qualitative and quantitative impacts of new projects. Projects should not move forward unless the cumulative impact assessment is net-positive, meaning, communities will benefit from a project instead of being harmed.

This set of policy recommendations is far from exhaustive. As climate change mitigation strategies and technologies evolve, so will this list. What is essential is how communities are protected and engaged as these solutions are deployed across the state.

The next section outlines some of the ways communities must benefit as the green energy transition continues.

Protections for Workers

- Ensuring Stability for Workers During the Energy Transition: Workers should not face economic hardship as a result of the shift to a clean energy economy. Companies undergoing transitions must prioritize retaining their workforce, offering training, and maintaining equitable compensation levels to ensure job security and dignity for all employees.
- Re-Training and Workforce Mobility: If retaining workers in transitioning industries is not feasible, the state of Mississippi must take an active role in connecting displaced workers to emerging industries with high labor demand. This includes partnering with clean energy, advanced manufacturing, and technology sectors to provide retraining programs that equip workers with skills for gainful, long-term employment.
- Union Support and Fair Labor Practices: Clean energy developers should prioritize hiring unionized labor, as union jobs often offer better wages, benefits, and protections. Developers must also commit to respecting workers' rights to organize and should never obstruct unionization efforts. Ensuring union participation will contribute to a fairer and more equitable energy transition.

7 Julius, S., S. Mazur, N. Tulve, S. Paul, N. Loschin, T. Barzyk, K. Buck, K. Dionisio, A. Geller, J. Hoffman, S. Lee, B. Owens, A. Shatas, D. Smith, J. Williams, O. Nweke, C. Lee, C. Braverman, AND M. Small. Cumulative Impacts: Recommendations for ORD Research. U.S. Environmental Protection Agency, Washington, DC, EPA/600/R-22/014a, 2022.

Community Benefit Plans and Agreements

- Leveraging the Inflation Reduction Act's Precedents: The Inflation Reduction Act required projects receiving Department of Energy funding to submit Community Benefit Plans, fostering accountability between developers and communities. Even if future administrations remove this mandate, developers should continue this practice voluntarily to ensure transparency and community engagement.
- Developing Binding Community Benefit Agreements: Ideally, developers and community representatives should negotiate legally enforceable Community Benefit Agreements (CBAs). These agreements would ensure that community needs—such as local hiring, environmental protections, and public infrastructure investments—are addressed and upheld throughout the project lifecycle.
- Accessing Financial Resources for Communities: Communities should actively pursue funding from state, federal, and philanthropic sources to develop and enforce robust benefit plans and agreements. These resources can empower communities to hold developers accountable while enabling sustainable, locally beneficial projects.

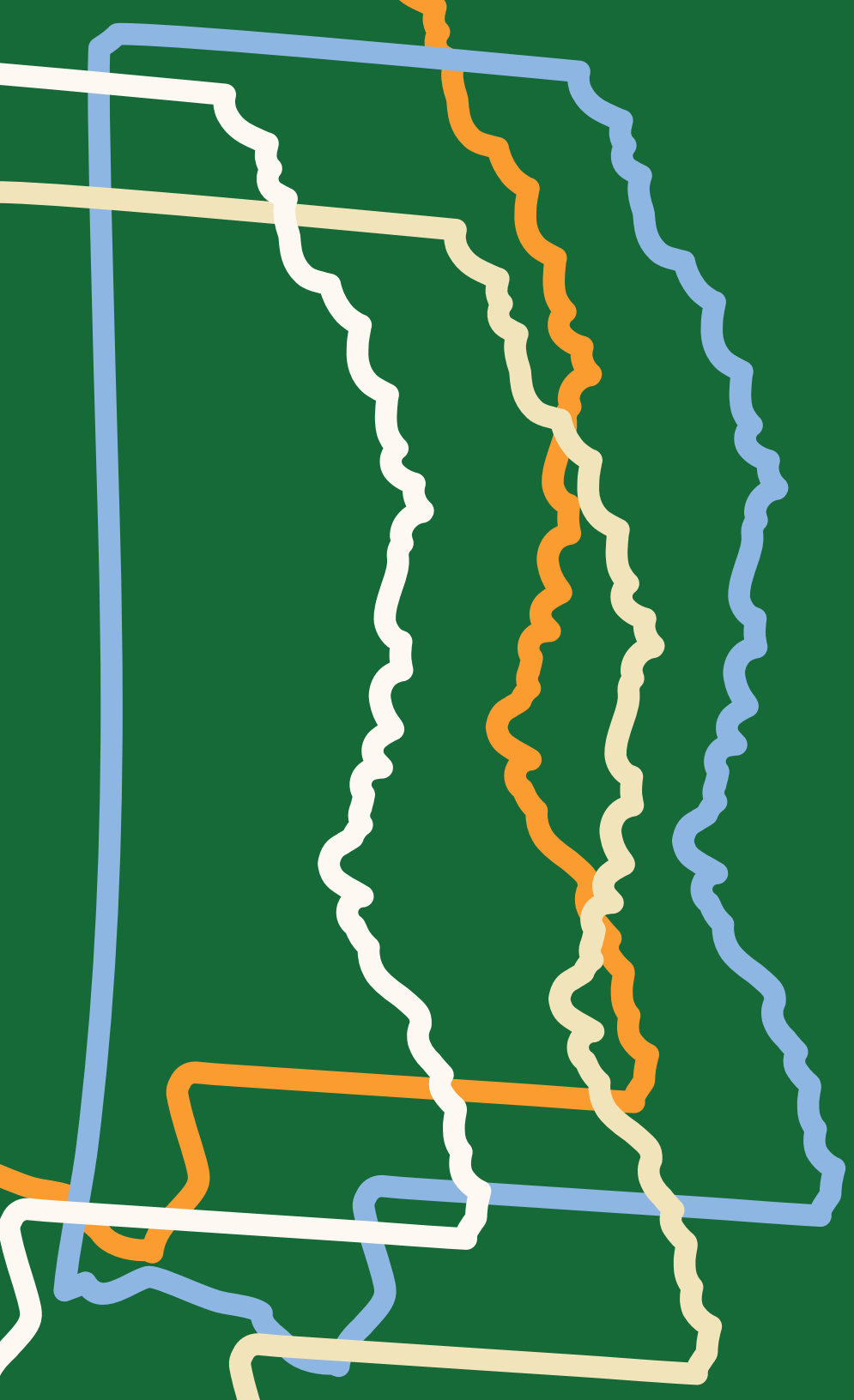
Cooperative and Collaborative Economic Development

- Fostering Community-Developer Collaboration: Economic development projects should prioritize collaboration between developers and communities. This requires consistent engagement, sustained climate education facilitated by trusted third parties, and a commitment to transparency. Building trust is essential for identifying best practices and ensuring mutual success.
- Revenue Sharing Agreements: Developers should explore revenue-sharing agreements that allow communities to directly benefit from the projects being built in their regions. By sharing economic gains with residents, developers can strengthen local support, reduce opposition, and ensure a fair distribution of wealth.
- Capacity Building and Long-Term Partnerships: Collaborative economic development should focus on building the capacity of local communities to participate in and benefit from projects. This includes providing technical assistance, leadership training, and resources to enable communities to advocate effectively for their interests and negotiate equitable outcomes.
- Reform the Mississippi Department of Environmental Quality's Permitting Process: Community input needs to be a central tenet of MDEQ's permitting process. The concerns of people most impacted by projects must be addressed by the state and project developers. Further, agency directors should release responses to the major themes identified in public meetings and comment periods in advance of the final vote.

Points of Advocacy

- **Mississippi Department of Environmental Quality Permitting Reform:** Require agency directors (not proxies) appointed by the Governor of Mississippi to attend public meetings organized by MDEQ.
- **Reform for local and statewide permitting and zoning processes:** Local officials need to coordinate planning and zoning decisions more clearly and transparently with statewide permit approval processes. Community members should have an abundance of time to provide feedback for both levels of the process.
- **Community Resilience Planning:** Build on the ongoing efforts of hub members to plan and develop resilience centers for community members at greatest risk of energy insecurity. Ensure reliable power access through solar energy and battery storage.
- **Public Service Commission Elections**: Advocate for candidates who prioritize climate action and clean energy development.
- **Pressuring Utility Companies**: Work with groups to hold Entergy, Southern Company, and Mississippi Power accountable for developing and implementing Just Transition plans.
- **Supporting Opposition Candidates**: Partner with national advocacy groups to run candidates in contested local elections and make climate action a central campaign issue. 60% of Mississippi legislative elections went uncontested last cycle.
- **Building Legislative Relationships**: Cultivate partnerships with legislators committed to economic development and aligned climate goals.
- **Promoting Energy Co-op Transformation**: Encourage energy cooperatives in non-monopoly areas to transition to solar and wind power.
- **Sustained Climate Education**: Establish long-term climate education initiatives through partnerships with universities and research institutions.





This report was compiled in a collaborative effort between The Great Plains Institute and the Mississippi People's Movement.